

BEFORE

Early civilization in the Americas centered initially on the Andes in South America, and later on Mesoamerica to the north.

EARLY CITIES

One of the **first cities** in the Americas was **Caral**, 125 miles (200 km) north of modern Lima, Peru. The city, which was well established by c. 2500 BCE, included **pyramid structures** built around the same time as those at Giza, Egypt.



CARAL EXCAVATIONS, MAY 2001

MESOAMERICAN CULTURE

By c. 1500 BCE, **agricultural settlements** had formed in the area archaeologists call Mesoamerica (central Honduras and Costa Rica to northern Mexico). The main crops were corn, beans, squash, chilis, and cotton. There was **not yet an urban culture** to rival that at Caral.

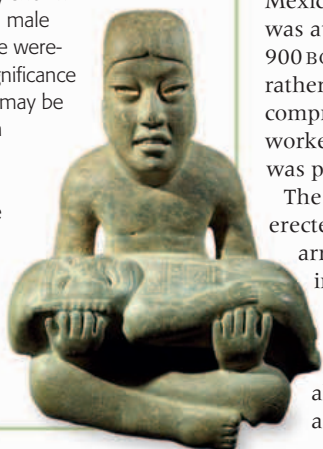
VOTIVE OBJECT An artifact offered to a deity as a gift of some kind in order to thank or appease them, or enhance the success of prayers. Small “votive axes” carved out of jade were common in Olmec culture.

IDEA

WERE-JAGUAR MYTHOLOGY

The jaguar, found across Mesoamerica and South America, was viewed with reverential fear by the early cultures of these regions. It was often depicted as a “were-jaguar,” which combined often infantlike human and jaguar features, typically with a downturned mouth, large lips, and oval eyes. The were-jaguar is especially associated with the Olmecs. It appeared as jade figurines and larger sculptures, and was carved into altars and other surfaces. Were-jaguar babies were common, usually shown held by a seated male figure (right). The were-jaguar’s exact significance is unclear, but it may be a “transformation figure” used by shamans to connect with the gods or harness the animal’s natural power.

FIGURINE OF SEATED MALE WITH WERE-JAGUAR BABY



The years between about 1500 and 900 BCE saw the first real stirrings of more advanced civilization in Mesoamerica. Agricultural skill and productivity improved, pottery became more complex (possibly through contact with Andean cultures in South America), and the temple-pyramid emerged. This was also the period when Mesoamerica’s first great civilization sprang to life—the Olmecs.

Life in the lowlands

The Olmecs established themselves in the humid, fertile lowlands of south Mexico, and their culture was flourishing by about 1200 BCE. By around 800 BCE their influence had

spread out over a wider area of Mesoamerica. It seems that Olmec symbolism was adopted by various other groups in Mesoamerica, possibly as a result of trading links.

Olmec farming practices were not particularly advanced, perhaps because they did not need to be, since the staple crop, corn, grew in ready abundance. The Olmecs were hunters rather than pastoralists, because there were no large herd animals in the region that could be domesticated. Animals were not used for transportation and, unlike in Eurasia, there were no wheeled vehicles—which, in any case, would have been of little use in the wet and swampy Olmec heartland.

The rise of San Lorenzo

The first important Olmec center was San Lorenzo, on a plateau above the Coatzacoalcos River in the southern Mexican state of Veracruz. San Lorenzo was at its height between 1200 and 900 BCE. It was most likely a chiefdom rather than a city-state, with a hierarchy comprising an elite class, skilled workers, and laborers. The population was possibly only around 1,000.

The buildings at San Lorenzo were erected on earthen mounds and arranged around open plazas. They included temples and houses made of poles and thatch, and the city seems to have had an advanced drainage system. There were also many stone monuments, such as giant carved heads, altarlike



Olmec civilization

The Olmecs’ heartland was quite small, but its culture spread from the Valley of Mexico in the northwest into present-day Belize, Guatemala, Honduras, and El Salvador in the east.



0 300 km
0 300 miles



People of the Jaguar

The first great civilizations of Mesoamerica and South America rivalled those of Mesopotamia, Ancient Egypt, and China. In Mesoamerica, the Olmecs established a blueprint for later cultures in the region. At the heart of Olmec belief was jaguar-worship, which they shared with their South American counterparts.



Giant head sculptures

The Olmecs are famed for their huge stone head sculptures, which were up to several yards (meters) tall and about 20 tons in weight. With distinctive flattened features, they are probably connected with Olmec gods.

structures, huge sculptures of seated people, and depictions of a variety of animals, most notably the jaguar (see left). Bloodletting and sacrifice may have been part of ritual practice, but this is purely speculation.

Near the San Lorenzo site, 1 mile (1.6 km) away at Cascajal, a stone dating from c. 900 BCE has been found bearing symbols that may be Olmec writing. This could suggest the Olmecs developed one of the first writing systems in Mesoamerica (see pp.62–63).

San Lorenzo seems to come to an end around 900 BCE. Evidence of widespread destruction of monuments has led some

experts to suggest that there was a major uprising or invasion. Others think that environmental factors may have caused San Lorenzo’s decline.

La Venta

The other major Olmec center was the city of La Venta, near the border of modern Tabasco and Veracruz states, which had a much larger population than San Lorenzo. Thriving between about 900 and 400 BCE, La Venta effectively took over from San Lorenzo as the principal Mesoamerican settlement. As at San Lorenzo, colossal stone heads and jaguar figures and imagery were found at La Venta, as well as temple-ceremonial complexes, including a giant pyramid. The major buildings at the site were all precisely aligned, perhaps linked with ideas about astronomy.

Olmec art was accomplished, especially its stone carving, including many small jade figures. Skilled relief carvings have been found at La Venta, along with other Olmec artifacts, including iron-ore mirrors that were worn around the neck. These may have been used by Olmec leaders as evidence of their “special” powers, as the mirrors could have been used to start fires or even project images.

